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Balancing AI and authenticity: EFL students' experiences with ChatGPT in academic writing

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ABSTRACT

This research explores the experiences of EFL students and their strategies when incorporating ChatGPT into their academic writing process. A qualitative case study method was employed, involving three EFL students with different proficiency levels. Data were collected through semi-structured interviews. Key findings indicate that ChatGPT is valued for overcoming uncertainties, clarifying vocabulary, and offering content suggestions, enhancing essay quality by allowing students to focus on creative aspects. However, balancing AI tools and human judgment is crucial for authenticity. ChatGPT raises concerns about the authenticity of academic work, highlighting the need for ethical guidelines and fostering critical thinking. Its limitations, such as providing overly complex suggestions and lacking cultural sensitivity, necessitate human oversight. Students recognize the importance of using their judgment and seeking feedback to ensure work quality. Educators should develop ethical guidelines for AI use in writing, emphasizing critical thinking and originality. Training programs for teachers and students on responsible AI integration are essential. Despite the comprehensive approach, the small sample size limits generalizability, and reliance on self-reported data introduces potential bias. Future research should involve larger, diverse samples and incorporate objective measures to mitigate bias.

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1. Introduction

There has been a marked increase in the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) tools in academic settings, driven by the rapid development of AI-assisted writing tools designed to aid students in their compositions (Gilbert, 2023; Jarrah et al., 2023; Lingard, 2023; Marzuki et al., 2023). A standout example is ChatGPT, developed by OpenAI, renowned for its coherent dialogue capabilities. However, the rise of these AI tools brings forward questions and potential pitfalls, especially concerning the impact on students' authentic voice. In pedagogical contexts, 'voice' does not just mean linguistic constructs; it encompasses unique perspectives, cultural nuances, and individual styles. This is even more pronounced in English as a Foreign Language (EFL) settings, where students must master a new language and retain their cultural imprints in their writing (Mageira et al., 2022; Nazari et al., 2021; Vall & Araya, 2023).

Understanding EFL students' experiences with ChatGPT is particularly relevant due to the dual challenge they face: achieving linguistic accuracy while preserving their cultural and individual expressions. The interplay between AI tools and the writing process is complex in the dynamic realm of EFL pedagogy. While AI platforms such as ChatGPT can accelerate linguistic competence, there is a concern that they might homogenize student outputs, potentially overriding nuanced, culturally-informed expressions (Feuston & Brubaker, 2021; Reiss, 2021). AI tools, despite their vast datasets, may not fully appreciate the subtle idiosyncrasies emblematic of a writer's background and experiences. For EFL students, this creates

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a balance between linguistic accuracy and authentic expression. The challenge is not the use of AI, but potential over-reliance, leading students to fit an AI-approved mold (Dai et al., 2020; Seo et al., 2021). As such, educators must integrate these tools judiciously, ensuring linguistic proficiency without stifling unique voices. Speculatively, future AI advancements might focus on cultural and individual sensitivity, fostering a balance between linguistic skills and genuine self-expression.

As briefly mentioned above, recent research has increasingly focused on the role of AI tools in the writing domain. Gilbert (2023) delved into the interactions between writers and AI, particularly when generative AI is utilized to alleviate writer's block. While traditionally writers sought feedback from peers to navigate creative obstacles, AI has emerged as a novel support mechanism. Notably, Gilbert (2023) highlighted how AI contributes to the iterative process of developing and refining written pieces. The study discovered that AI tools could mimic distinct facets of creative writing, such as manifesting one's unique voice and the pursuit of a genuine self-expression. Wong et al. (2023) assessed the efficacy of neural language generation (NLG) tools within creative writing, specifically leveraging the wordcraft text editor enhanced by AI capabilities. Engaging 13 seasoned writers, findings revealed that although NLG has its merits in brainstorming, generating details, world-building, and research, it still grapples with maintaining the individualistic voice of adept writers and often falls short in grasping intricate narratives. This underscores the imperative for AI writing tools such as ChatGPT to be finely attuned to the diverse needs and objectives of writers to truly optimize their potential. However, while these studies touch on AI's ability (or lack thereof) to maintain a writer's unique voice, they do not delve deeply into how AI tools might be personalized or tailored for individual writers over time.

Lingard (2023) conducted an in-depth analysis of ChatGPT's strengths and drawbacks, offering writers insights into its optimal application for various writing endeavors. Marzuki et al. (2023) focused on a range of AI writing tools and their influence on student compositions, especially regarding content and structure, through the lens of educators teaching English as a Foreign Language (EFL). Their research posited that the inclusion of AI writing tools can significantly elevate the writing caliber of EFL students. As with earlier research, a significant limitation of these latter studies is their oversight regarding the direct experiences of students using AI tools like ChatGPT. Furthermore, neither study delves into strategies used to preserve the genuine voice of the writer, leaving a potential research gap in understanding the personalization of AI tools for writing.

Against this backdrop, the current study is embarking on a focused exploration into the nexus between EFL students and ChatGPT, a leading AI tool, during their writing endeavors. The objective of this study is to thoroughly explore the experiences of EFL students and the practical strategies they employ when incorporating ChatGPT into their writing process. At the heart of this investigation are two pivotal questions: How do EFL students perceive and describe their experiences with using ChatGPT as an aid in essay writing? and What strategies or approaches do EFL students adopt when interacting with ChatGPT during the essay writing process? By holistically addressing these questions, the study aspires to illuminate the multifaceted relationship between EFL students and ChatGPT, offering insights that could potentially guide future pedagogical decisions, tool enhancements, and curriculum integrations in the domain of language education.

1.1. The proliferation of AI in the writing landscape

Artificial Intelligence's foray into the world of writing is nothing short of transformative. One of the primary advantages AI brings to the table is its ability to enhance and streamline the writing process (Alasadi & Baiz, 2023; Althabatah et al., 2023). Advanced AI writing tools are capable of rapid content generation, enabling writers and content producers to churn out extensive pieces with remarkable efficiency. These tools leverage vast datasets and sophisticated algorithms, ensuring the generated content is both relevant and contextually accurate (Carvalho & Ivanov, 2024; Wardat et al., 2023). Moreover, the added layer of sophisticated proofreading capabilities, which transcend mere grammar and spell checks to include style, tone, and voice adjustments, underscores the meticulousness with which AI approaches the domain of writing. Such advancements ensure that the content is not only error-free but also aligns seamlessly with the desired brand or personal voice (Nazari et al., 2021; Vall & Araya, 2023).

Beyond automation and editing, the personalization aspect of AI writing tools is particularly notable. By analyzing user data and preferences (with strict adherence to privacy norms), these tools can tailor content to resonate with specific target audiences. Whether it is crafting a marketing message for a niche demographic or translating content to cater to a global audience without sacrificing the intricacies of language, AI writing tools are proving indispensable. This personalization capability, married to the tool's ability to analyze vast datasets, paves the way for research-intensive, data-driven writing. For instance, a writer can rely on AI to sift through expansive research documents, extract key points, and then weave them into a coherent narrative, all within a fraction of the traditional timeframe (Song & Luximon, 2020).

However, as with any powerful tool, AI writing platforms come with their set of challenges and considerations. The most pressing concern for many is the potential erosion of authenticity in AI-generated content. While the output might be grammatically impeccable and data-driven, it may lack the genuine human touch that often gives writing its depth and emotional resonance. This absence can sometimes render the content sterile or overly mechanical. Additionally, there is a very real concern about the over-reliance on AI (Dai et al., 2020; Seo et al., 2021). When used as a crutch rather than an aid, AI tools might inadvertently stifle human creativity and curtail the organic development of writing skills. On the ethical frontier, the potential misuse of AI-generated content, especially when it is not properly vetted, might lead to the spread of misinformation or content that is misleading (Alneyadi & Wardat, 2023; De Angelis et al., 2023). Speculatively peering into the future, it is exciting to envision the collaborative potential between AI and human writers. While current AI tools such as ChatGPT offer suggestions and enhancements, future iterations might truly co-write with humans (Jarrah et al., 2023). Imagine an AI tool that, in real-time, suggests plot twists for a novelist, research data for a journalist, or design descriptions for a product reviewer. As AI systems continue to learn and adapt, they might also evolve to reflect real-time cultural shifts, ensuring the content remains contemporary and relevant in an ever-changing world.

1.2. EFL writing and pedagogical challenges in the AI era

English as a Foreign Language (EFL) writing presents unique challenges, particularly in maintaining linguistic accuracy while preserving students' authentic voices. EFL students must navigate new linguistic landscapes while retaining their cultural imprints in their writing (Mageira et al., 2022; Nazari et al., 2021; Vall & Araya, 2023). Learning to write in a new language involves mastering grammar, vocabulary, and syntax while understanding and integrating cultural contexts. This dual task can be daunting as students strive to express complex ideas clearly and accurately in a non-native language while conveying their unique perspectives and cultural identities (Besral et al., 2021; Kim, 2020). Pedagogical approaches in EFL settings emphasize fostering students' unique perspectives, cultural nuances, and individual styles. Teachers encourage students to draw on their personal experiences and cultural backgrounds as sources of inspiration and authenticity in their writing. This approach enriches the content of their compositions and helps students develop a sense of ownership and pride in their work (Lavrenteva & Orland-Barak, 2022; Samarji, 2020). As such, meaningful and relevant writing tasks promote engagement and motivation, which are critical for effective language learning.

In the AI era, educators face the challenge of integrating AI tools into the EFL curriculum in a way that supports linguistic development without undermining authenticity. This requires a careful and balanced approach. Teachers need to guide students on how to use AI tools effectively, emphasizing that these tools are aids rather than replacements for their own creative and critical thinking (Celik, 2023; Owan et al., 2023). Instruction should focus on helping students understand AI feedback and use it to enhance, rather than overshadow, their unique voices. Additionally, educators should encourage students to critically assess AI suggestions and make informed decisions about which changes to incorporate. Furthermore, ongoing research and development are needed to improve AI tools to better support the preservation of authenticity in EFL writing. Future advancements in AI could include more sophisticated algorithms that consider the cultural and individual contexts of the writer, producing feedback and suggestions that enhance rather than dilute the writer's unique voice. By fostering a symbiotic relationship between AI technology and human creativity, it is possible to create a writing environment that

maximizes linguistic proficiency while celebrating and preserving the rich diversity of student expressions (Jarrah et al., 2023; Lavrenteva & Orland-Barak, 2022).

1.3. AI tools in EFL writing: the ChatGPT

The use of AI tools in EFL writing has gained traction due to their ability to support linguistic development and streamline the writing process (Marzuki et al., 2023; Reiss, 2021). These tools offer features such as grammar checks, style suggestions, and content generation, which can significantly enhance EFL students' writing skills. Grammar checks help students correct syntactical and grammatical errors, ensuring their writing adheres to the conventions of English. Style suggestions assist in refining the tone and coherence of their essays, making their writing more polished and professional. Content generation aids in brainstorming ideas and structuring their essays, which is particularly beneficial for students struggling with writer's block or organizing their thoughts.

However, integrating AI tools in EFL writing introduces a complex interplay between achieving linguistic proficiency and maintaining authenticity in student compositions. AI writing tools, such as ChatGPT, offer significant linguistic support by providing immediate feedback on grammar, spelling, and syntax errors, suggesting improvements in style and tone, and generating content ideas (Jarrah et al., 2023; Javaid et al., 2023). This can be particularly valuable for EFL students struggling with the technical aspects of writing in a new language. By using AI tools, students can produce more polished and grammatically accurate texts, boosting their confidence and facilitating language acquisition. Despite these advantages, there are concerns that reliance on AI tools might lead to homogenized writing styles and a loss of individuality. AI-generated content, while linguistically sound, may lack the depth, emotional resonance, and cultural specificity that characterize authentic human writing (Rahmeh, 2023; Zhang et al., 2024). EFL students may find it challenging to balance the technical correctness provided by AI with the need to infuse their writing with personal voice and cultural identity. Thus, over-reliance on AI tools might result in compositions that are technically proficient but devoid of the unique qualities reflecting the writer's background and experiences (Dai et al., 2020; Dwivedi et al., 2023; Feuston & Brubaker, 2021).

To address these concerns, educators must adopt a balanced approach in integrating AI tools like ChatGPT within the EFL curriculum. They should encourage students to use these tools as aids rather than replacements for their own thinking and creativity (Jarrah et al., 2023; Lavrenteva & Orland-Barak, 2022). By combining the strengths of AI with human oversight and personal effort, students can achieve linguistic proficiency while maintaining the authenticity and richness of their individual voices. This integrated approach can help harness the benefits of AI while mitigating its potential drawbacks, fostering a more effective and enriching learning experience for EFL students.

1.4. Preservation of authenticity in writing

The preservation of authenticity in writing is a critical issue, particularly in the context of AI-generated content. Authenticity encompasses the unique voice, cultural nuances, and personal expression of the writer, reflecting their individual experiences and background. Authentic writing resonates deeply with readers, conveying true intentions, emotions, and perspectives. Studies highlight the importance of maintaining these elements to ensure the depth and emotional resonance of written content (Gilburt, 2023; Wong et al., 2023). Authentic writing fosters engagement and empathy, making the content relatable and compelling, especially in educational settings where personal and cultural expressions are integral to learning and identity development.

The challenge lies in balancing the use of AI tools for linguistic accuracy with the preservation of genuine self-expression. AI tools provide suggestions for grammar, style, and content but may not fully capture the writer's unique voice. Over-reliance on AI can lead to a homogenized writing style, lacking individual expression, which is particularly concerning for EFL students. Existing literature suggests that AI tools must be used judiciously to avoid stifling creativity and individuality (De Angelis et al., 2023; Seo et al., 2021). Writers should use AI as a supplementary tool, ensuring their own voice and ideas remain at the forefront. Educators play a crucial role in guiding students on integrating AI without compromising authenticity, emphasizing personal reflection and creativity in writing. As such, ongoing

research and development are needed to improve AI tools to better support authenticity. Future AI advancements could include algorithms that consider the writer's cultural and individual contexts, offering more personalized and relevant suggestions. This would help bridge the gap between linguistic accuracy and authentic expression, allowing writers to produce high-quality content true to their unique voice.

1.5. Theoretical foundations and existing studies

A comprehensive understanding of the interplay between EFL writing, AI tools, and authenticity preservation requires a review of existing studies and theories in this area. Theoretical foundations such as sociocultural theory provide insights into the complexities of language learning and writing (Vygotsky & Cole, 1978). Sociocultural theory, as proposed by Vygotsky, emphasizes the role of social interaction and cultural context in language development. According to this theory, learning is a socially mediated process, where interaction with more knowledgeable others, such as teachers and peers, plays a crucial role in cognitive development. In the context of EFL writing, sociocultural theory suggests that students benefit from collaborative learning environments where they can share ideas, receive feedback, and engage in meaningful dialogue. This interaction helps students internalize new language structures and develop their writing skills within their cultural contexts.

Research on the use of AI tools in education emphasizes the potential benefits and drawbacks, highlighting the need for balanced integration to support both linguistic development and authentic expression. Studies by Carvalho and Ivanov (2024) demonstrate that AI tools can significantly enhance the writing process by offering real-time feedback, generating ideas, and correcting errors. These tools can help EFL students improve their linguistic accuracy, expand their vocabulary, and develop a better understanding of grammatical structures. The immediate feedback provided by AI can accelerate the learning process, allowing students to identify and correct mistakes quickly. However, the integration of AI tools also presents challenges. One major concern is the potential for AI to overshadow the human elements of writing, such as creativity, personal expression, and cultural nuances. Research indicates that while AI can assist with technical aspects of writing, it may not fully capture the depth and richness of human expression. For example, Carvalho and Ivanov (2024) found that AI-generated content, though grammatically correct, often lacked the emotional and cultural resonance that comes from personal experience. This suggests that while AI can be a valuable tool for enhancing linguistic accuracy, it should be used in conjunction with human oversight to ensure that the authenticity of the writer's voice is preserved.

In conclusion, the interplay between EFL writing, AI tools, and authenticity preservation is complex and multifaceted. Theoretical foundations such as sociocultural theory provide valuable insights into the processes of language learning and writing. Existing research highlights the potential benefits of AI tools for enhancing linguistic accuracy and supporting language acquisition, but also underscores the importance of preserving the authenticity of student writing. A balanced approach that integrates AI tools with human oversight and emphasizes personal and cultural expression can help achieve the dual goals of linguistic proficiency and authentic writing.

2. Method

2.1. Research design

The study employed a qualitative case study design to delve deep into the specific experiences of EFL students using ChatGPT in their writing process. This design is particularly apt for this investigation as it allows for an in-depth exploration of complex issues within their real-world contexts, presenting a holistic understanding of the phenomena in question (Yin, 2014). Such a design offers an avenue to generate detailed insights from a limited number of participants, capturing the nuanced interactions and unique perspectives they have concerning their use of ChatGPT. Furthermore, a qualitative case study approach was chosen because it provides a flexible and contextually rich framework for investigating phenomena that are not easily quantifiable. This approach focuses on understanding the 'how' and 'why' questions, emphasizing processes and outcomes that are context-dependent. By prioritizing depth over breadth,

this approach seeks to provide a comprehensive portrayal of the students' experiences and the practical tactics they employ, which might be overlooked in broader, quantitative designs (Stake, 1995).

2.2. Research participants

The research focused on EFL students enrolled in the English Department at an Indonesian university, aiming to investigate their experiences with incorporating ChatGPT into their writing practices. Before commencing, informed consent was obtained from all potential participants, ensuring they fully understood the research's purpose, procedures, and implications. Their rights, including the option to withdraw at any time without penalty, were explicitly communicated to uphold ethical integrity.

A convenience purposive sampling technique was employed, targeting individuals who could offer specific insights pertinent to the research objectives. Criteria for selection included prior experience with chatbots, proficiency in English, and the frequency of written assignments. These criteria ensured the selection of participants who could provide rich and relevant data. Based on this, potential participants underwent a detailed review, and their responses were analyzed for compatibility with the research objectives. This rigorous process led to the final selection of three students who best aligned with the research aims. The selection of these three students was justified by their diverse experiences and backgrounds, which provided a comprehensive understanding of the research topic. Their varied proficiency levels and chatbot interactions ensured a balanced representation of the target population, enhancing the validity and reliability of the findings (see Table 1 for details).

Acknowledging the time and effort participants would invest in this research, an incentive was considered necessary. Each selected student received a small voucher, serving both as a token of appreciation and an encouragement for their active engagement.

2.3. Research instrument

The main instrument employed for this research was the semi-structured interview. This format was selected for several reasons. First, semi-structured interviews provide a balance between the rigidity of structured interviews and the freedom of unstructured interviews. This allows the researcher to probe deeper into certain areas when necessary, capturing nuanced insights while still adhering to a predefined set of questions. Second, such interviews facilitate an in-depth exploration of the participant's experiences, feelings, and perceptions, offering a richer dataset compared to surveys or structured questionnaires. Third, given the diverse experiences of EFL students with ChatGPT, the semi-structured format ensures that each interview can be slightly tailored to the individual participant, while still remaining within the research's framework. We developed interview questions based on several current literature reviews (De Togni et al., 2021; Riveiro & Thill, 2021). Each interview session was designed to last approximately 60 minutes, though slight deviations were expected based on the depth and richness of each participant's responses. Participants were seated in a quiet, comfortable environment to ensure they felt at ease. After a brief introduction and reiteration of the research's purpose, the interview commenced. Questions were open-ended, giving participants the freedom to express their experiences in their own words. The researcher took notes and used audio recording equipment (with participant's consent) to capture responses verbatim. Upon completion of each interview, audio recordings were transcribed. These transcriptions, along with the researcher's notes, formed the primary data source for analysis. Care was taken to ensure the confidentiality and anonymity of participants' responses.

2.4. Data analysis

We utilized a thematic case study method to examine the qualitative information. Following the approach suggested by Braun and Clarke (2006), the intent of our thematic evaluation was to pinpoint recurring

Table 1. Demography of participants.

Participants	Experiences in Using ChatGPT (year)	English Proficiency Level	Frequency of written assignments	Degree level
R1	1	Intermediate	Monthly	Undergraduate
R2	>1	Intermediate	Weekly	Graduate
R3	>1	Advanced	Weekly	Graduate

motifs and connections within themes sourced from the qualitative material, aiming to address the objectives of our study. We broke down our analysis into five separate stages.

During the initial stage, we meticulously reviewed the interview transcript on multiple occasions to gain a deep understanding of its contents. In the subsequent phase, we generated initial codes that collated relevant terms and expressions according to our study's standards. After a comprehensive scrutiny of these codes, we proceeded to classify each. In this phase, we also juxtaposed the findings to discern potential correlations or recurring patterns. Ultimately, we derived a collection of categories based on these consolidated codes.

2.5. Ethical considerations

Ethical considerations were paramount in this study, particularly when dealing with technology and student data. Informed consent was obtained from all participants, ensuring they fully understood the research's purpose, procedures, and potential implications, including their right to withdraw at any time without penalty. To protect participants' privacy, all data collected was anonymized, with personal identifiers removed and unique codes assigned to ensure confidentiality. Data was stored securely on encrypted servers to prevent unauthorized access, and any data shared with third parties was also anonymized. Ethical use of technology was emphasized, with participants being informed about the AI's capabilities and limitations to mitigate potential misconceptions. The study was designed to minimize any potential harm, with carefully crafted interview questions and support resources provided for participants. After the study, participants were debriefed on the findings, validating their involvement and addressing any residual concerns. By implementing these measures, the study maintained high ethical standards, ensuring the protection of participants' rights and data.

3. Findings

The findings of the research are twofold: the perceptions of EFL students regarding the use of ChatGPT for essay writing, and the strategies they employ with ChatGPT in essay writing. Each of these aspects is elaborated in detail subsequently.

3.1. EFL students' perceptions of using ChatGPT for essay writing

The initial research findings reveal three key themes in EFL students' perceptions of ChatGPT for writing: its value as an assistance and support tool, the challenges and limitations it presents, and the potential risk of over-reliance. Each of these themes are explored in detail in the following sections.

3.1.1. Assistance and support

The participants consistently viewed ChatGPT as a valuable writing assistant. R1 found it particularly helpful in overcoming moments of uncertainty, offering clarity on vocabulary and concepts, and even providing content suggestions for articulating ideas like the importance of English. R2 echoed this sentiment, highlighting the platform's assistance in structuring sentences and paragraphs, and providing feedback on grammar and vocabulary. Likewise, R3 found ChatGPT's guidance invaluable for clarifying complex terms and correcting grammatical errors, ultimately improving the overall quality of their essays. Excerpts from participant responses are detailed below:

R1: "[...] ChatGPT has helped me a lot with my English essays. When I am stuck or not sure about a word or idea, I ask ChatGPT [...]"

R2: "[...] ChatGPT has been very helpful for me in many ways. Firstly, it helps me with grammar and vocabulary which I sometimes struggle with. [...] once I was writing an essay about global warming and I was not sure about the correct use of some technical terms. ChatGPT helped me understand and use them correctly [...]"

R3: "[...] In my writing, ChatGPT helps a lot. I often have ideas, but I do not know the best English words to use. [...] Another time, I made a mistake with verb tenses, and ChatGPT corrected it, making my essay sound better [...]"

It can be concluded that participants consistently perceived ChatGPT as a valuable writing assistant, aiding in overcoming uncertainty, clarifying vocabulary and concepts, suggesting content, structuring sentences and paragraphs, and improving grammar and overall essay quality.

3.1.2. Challenges and limitations

The subsequent issue identified by the EFL students pertained to the challenges and limitations of ChatGPT. R1 noted that the platform's suggestions were occasionally overly complex or formal, deviating from their intended writing style. R2 expressed that the feedback provided did not always align with their desired tone. Furthermore, R3 observed that ChatGPT sometimes struggled to grasp cultural nuances or offered suggestions that were stereotypical in nature. The following represents a selection of participant responses.

R1: "[...] Sometimes, ChatGPT gives suggestions that sound too formal or complicated for what I want to say [...]"

R2: "[...] there were a few times when I felt the suggestions did not match the tone or style I was aiming for in my essay [...]"

R3: "[...] I wanted to write an essay about my culture, and I asked ChatGPT for some ideas. Some of the suggestions it gave were not very accurate or they were a bit stereotypical [...]"

Based on the aforementioned feedback, it can be concluded that while ChatGPT serves as a valuable writing tool, it is essential for users to critically evaluate its suggestions and tailor them to their specific needs and cultural context.

3.1.3. Over-reliance risk

Although ChatGPT proved to be a helpful tool in the writing process, the participants recognized the importance of exercising their own judgment and critical thinking skills to mitigate the risk of over-reliance. They often sought feedback and guidance from human sources, such as teachers or peers, when ChatGPT's suggestions did not align with their intuition or understanding of the task. This demonstrates that while AI can enhance the writing process, it should not replace critical thinking and human judgment in crafting effective and nuanced communication. Presented below are the selected responses of the participants.

R1: "[...] If I think ChatGPT's idea does not fit my essay or is too hard for me, I just do not use it. Sometimes I ask my teacher or friends for their opinion [...]"

R2: "[...] When I disagree with ChatGPT's feedback, I try to think about why I disagree. Sometimes I ask my teacher or classmates for their opinion [...]"

R3: "[...] If I disagree with ChatGPT, I try to think about why. Sometimes I ask my teacher or friends for their opinion [...]"

In a nutshell, the experiences of these three EFL learners reveal a consistent pattern: while ChatGPT offers valuable support in essay writing, it is not a substitute for critical thinking and human guidance. Participants appreciated the platform's assistance in overcoming language-related challenges, such as vocabulary and grammar, and generating ideas for their essays. However, they also recognized the limitations of the AI, such as its occasional inability to understand nuanced context or provide culturally relevant feedback. This led them to exercise their own judgment and seek feedback from human sources, such as teachers or peers, when ChatGPT's suggestions fell short. This highlights the importance of personal agency and cultural awareness in navigating the use of AI tools in language learning. The experiences of these learners also underscore the potential of AI to complement, rather than replace, human instruction. By combining the strengths of AI with human guidance, EFL students can develop their writing skills more effectively while honing their critical thinking abilities and cultural understanding.

3.2. EFL students' strategies with ChatGPT in essay writing

In exploring the various strategies employed by EFL students when integrating ChatGPT into their writing practices, it becomes evident that each student has a unique approach tailored to their specific needs. There were three themes emerge based on the students' responses: assistance with linguistic refinement, idea generation and structuring and proofreading and confidence enhancement. Each the themes are detailed in the following sections.

3.2.1. Assistance with linguistic refinement

R1 leveraged ChatGPT as a pivotal resource during the writing process. She primarily utilizes ChatGPT for linguistic refinement, which encompasses enhancing vocabulary and sentence structure. This assistance is particularly beneficial when encountering challenges or navigating transitions in writing, thereby facilitating a smoother and more polished final output. The following are R1's views:

R1: "[...] I then turn to ChatGPT if I am stuck with vocabulary or if I am unsure about a particular sentence structure [...] "When I start writing an essay, my first step is to jot down my initial thoughts and ideas. After I have a basic outline or draft, I then turn to ChatGPT [...] Sometimes, I feel that I might be relying too much on ChatGPT, and I worry if my voice is getting lost [...]"

3.2.2. Idea generation and structuring

Quite different from R1, R2 tends to use ChatGPT as an aid in the initial stages of writing. R2 employs ChatGPT for brainstorming and idea generation before drafting an essay. This preliminary use helps in organizing thoughts and creating a coherent structure. Once this framework is established, R2 drafts the essay independently. Subsequently, ChatGPT is utilized again for proofreading, ensuring that the final piece is polished and free of errors. The following is a selection from R2's responses:

R2: "[...] Before I even start writing, I usually have a brainstorming session with ChatGPT. [...] Once I have a structure in mind, I'll draft my essay without ChatGPT's help [...] I use ChatGPT primarily for proofreading [...] It's crucial not to let the tool overshadow the original intent and simplicity of my writing [...]"

3.2.3. Proofreading and confidence enhancement

Similarly, R3 incorporates ChatGPT into their writing process, but with a distinct focus. R3 relies on ChatGPT as a safety net, especially for finalizing essays and navigating complex sections. This strategy is used to boost confidence and ensure coherence, providing a final check to enhance the overall quality of the writing. Below are the insights provided by R3 in the interview:

R3: "[...] The tool helps me finalize the ending of my essay and improve coherence in complicated sections [...] ChatGPT has been a confidence booster for me. [...] knowing that I can rely on it to catch language errors or guide me when I am unsure has made essay writing less intimidating [...] there were moments when I questioned if an essay was truly 'mine' or if it was becoming a collaborative effort with a machine [...]"

In the accounts of these three participants, a subtle pattern emerges concerning their use and reliance on ChatGPT. At the core of their interactions lies ChatGPT's role as a linguistic tool, providing guidance in terms of vocabulary and sentence structure. While each participant has their own distinct methods for incorporating the platform, they all turn to it when faced with uncertainties or when seeking to enhance their essays. Their engagement spans various stages, starting from initial brainstorming, moving through mid-writing refinements, and even extending to the final proofreading phase. However, a shared sense of caution permeates their experiences, marked by a strong awareness of the importance of preserving their unique voice and authenticity in their writing. This delicate balance between leveraging technology for refinement and upholding personal expression stands as the focal point of the EFL students' interaction with ChatGPT during their essay-writing journey. These testimonies underscore the tool's value as a supportive resource while underscoring the enduring significance of individual judgment in the learning process.

4. Discussion

The aim of this research is to gain a comprehensive understanding of the experiences of EFL students and the practical strategies they use when integrating ChatGPT into their writing process. The initial findings from this research, focusing on the EFL students' perspectives on ChatGPT, revealed several key points.

Firstly, participants consistently viewed ChatGPT as a valuable writing assistant, finding it particularly helpful in overcoming moments of uncertainty, clarifying vocabulary and concepts, and offering content suggestions. This indicates that ChatGPT serves as both a tool for linguistic correction and a cognitive aid that helps users refine and expand their ideas (Marzuki et al., 2023). EFL students also highlighted that the platform's assistance in structuring sentences and paragraphs and providing feedback on grammar and vocabulary, significantly enhancing the overall quality of their essays. The ability to structure content coherently and receive immediate corrections allows students to focus more on the creative and intellectual aspects of writing, rather than getting bogged down by technical details (Jarrah et al., 2023; Javaid et al., 2023). This feedback loop creates a learning environment where students can continuously refine their writing, leading to better academic outcomes and a deeper understanding of the English language. The consistent positive feedback from participants underscores the potential of AI-driven tools like ChatGPT to transform educational practices by making learning more accessible and personalized (Wardat et al., 2023).

However, the balance between using AI tools and human judgment in writing is delicate and has implications for authenticity. While ChatGPT provides substantial benefits, it also raises concerns about the authenticity of the work produced and the role of human judgment in maintaining academic integrity (Dai et al., 2020; Seo et al., 2021). The line between AI-generated content and the student's original work can become blurred, potentially undermining the authenticity of academic submissions. To address this, educators and students must develop strategies to ensure that AI tools complement rather than replace human creativity and critical thinking (Darwin et al., 2024; Jarrah et al., 2023; Lavrenteva & Orland-Barak, 2022). Clear guidelines on the acceptable use of AI in academic writing are essential, as is fostering an understanding of when to rely on AI and when to engage in independent thought (De Angelis et al., 2023; Seo et al., 2021). Ethical considerations must also be taken into account to ensure that students use these tools responsibly and that their work remains a genuine reflection of their abilities and knowledge (Nguyen et al., 2023).

The second issue highlighted by the EFL students involved the challenges and limitations of ChatGPT. They noted that the platform's suggestions were sometimes overly complex or formal, diverging from their intended writing style. Additionally, the feedback provided did not always match their desired tone, indicating a gap between the AI's responses and the specific stylistic preferences of the users. Furthermore, ChatGPT occasionally had difficulty understanding cultural nuances and sometimes offered stereotypical suggestions, highlighting a significant limitation in its ability to provide culturally sensitive and relevant content. This suggests that while ChatGPT can be valuable for general language assistance, its limitations become apparent in more nuanced, culturally-specific contexts (Alneyadi & Wardat, 2023; Berberich et al., 2020; Lindeman et al., 2021; Nawaz et al., 2022). Therefore, continued human oversight and intervention are essential to ensure that the writing remains authentic and culturally appropriate (Tromble, 2020; Verganti et al., 2020).

The third point is that participants recognized the importance of exercising their own judgment and critical thinking skills to avoid over-reliance on ChatGPT. They frequently sought feedback and guidance from human sources, such as teachers or peers, when ChatGPT's suggestions did not align with their intuition or understanding of the task. This indicates that while AI can enhance the writing process, it should not replace critical thinking and human judgment in crafting effective and nuanced communication (Ibna Seraj et al., 2022; Rauter et al., 2019; Riveiro & Thill, 2021). The participants understood that while ChatGPT could offer valuable assistance, it is essential to apply their own discernment to ensure the quality and accuracy of their work. The reliance on human feedback underscores the collaborative nature of learning and the continued relevance of human expertise in education (Porter & Grippa, 2020; Wardat et al., 2023). By integrating AI with critical thinking and peer consultation, students can achieve a more comprehensive and well-rounded understanding of their writing tasks. Additionally, AI has the potential to enhance human qualities by augmenting cognitive processes, fostering creativity, and

providing diverse perspectives that stimulate deeper intellectual engagement and innovation. Through this synergy, students can leverage AI tools to enhance their learning experience while simultaneously developing essential human skills such as judgment, creativity, and collaboration.

The next key findings of this research pertain to the strategies EFL students use when incorporating ChatGPT into their writing process. It was discovered that each EFL student has a unique approach tailored to their specific needs. One student utilized ChatGPT as a crucial resource throughout the writing process, primarily for linguistic refinement, including vocabulary and sentence structure enhancement. This assistance was particularly valuable for overcoming challenges and transitions, leading to a smoother, more polished final product. This approach highlights the significant role AI can play in writing. By improving vocabulary and sentence structure, ChatGPT helps students overcome common obstacles, streamlining the writing process and boosting confidence (Liu et al., 2023; Malik et al., 2023). It acts as a personalized tutor, providing real-time feedback and adjustments tailored to individual needs, resulting in a more coherent and well-crafted piece of writing. This example underscores the importance of integrating AI tools like ChatGPT into educational practices to support and enhance student learning.

Another student used ChatGPT as a valuable aid during the initial stages of writing. They employ ChatGPT for brainstorming and idea generation before beginning to draft an essay. This preliminary use of the AI tool helps in organizing thoughts and creating a coherent structure. Once this framework is established, the student drafts the essay independently. After completing the draft, they use ChatGPT again for proofreading to ensure the final piece is polished and error-free. This approach demonstrates a strategic use of AI to enhance the writing process. By leveraging ChatGPT for brainstorming, the student can generate a wide range of ideas and effectively organize them into a structured outline. This helps streamline the drafting process, allowing the student to focus on developing their arguments and content without getting bogged down by initial planning (Javaid et al., 2023; Kipp et al., 2024). Using ChatGPT for proofreading after drafting ensures that the essay is not only well-structured but also free of grammatical errors and other issues. This two-stage interaction with ChatGPT, first for idea generation and then for final refinement, shows how AI can be integrated into different phases of writing to improve overall quality. It highlights the potential for AI to support students in both the creative and technical aspects of writing, making the process more efficient and the final output more polished and professional (Kacena et al., 2024; Strobl et al., 2019).

One student also incorporates ChatGPT into the writing process with a distinct focus. This student relies on ChatGPT as a safety net, particularly for finalizing essays and navigating complex sections. This strategy is used to boost confidence and ensure coherence, providing a final check to enhance the overall quality of the writing. This approach highlights the role of AI in providing reassurance and support during critical stages of writing. By using ChatGPT to tackle complex sections and finalize their work, the student can address any uncertainties and refine their arguments, leading to a more coherent and polished essay. This strategy also underscores the confidence-boosting aspect of AI tools, allowing students to feel more secure in their writing abilities (Marzuki et al., 2023; Song & Song, 2023). Ultimately, this method demonstrates how AI can be effectively integrated as a supportive tool to enhance the quality and coherence of academic writing.

Based on the insightful findings above, this research presents important implications for various stakeholders in the educational landscape. Firstly, educators should develop clear guidelines for using AI in writing, focusing on critical thinking and originality. These guidelines should explain how to use AI tools as aids for tasks like grammar correction, vocabulary enhancement, and idea generation, while emphasizing the importance of personal input and creativity. Teachers should encourage students to critically evaluate AI suggestions, discerning beneficial ones and maintaining authenticity (Cope et al., 2021). Secondly, institutions should offer comprehensive training for both teachers and students on integrating AI. This training should cover effective AI tool use and ethical implications, with practical skills for students and balanced curriculum strategies for teachers. Workshops and hands-on sessions can support these training objectives (Lameras & Arnab, 2021; Schiff, 2022). Additionally, practical implications include demonstrating specific ways to integrate AI tools into writing practices. For instance, using AI for initial drafts, then refining and expanding ideas manually, or employing AI to identify and correct common writing errors before human review. Educators can also introduce exercises where students compare AI-generated text with their own to develop critical analysis skills. Lastly, AI developers should enhance

cultural sensitivity and provide customizable feedback, respecting diverse writing styles and tones. They should create AI systems that learn from user input for more personalized assistance and prompt independent thought, supporting human creativity. This approach, combining ethical guidelines, training, and advanced AI development, will help support EFL students while preserving their work's authenticity, ensuring AI tools are used responsibly and effectively without compromising personal growth and academic integrity (Chen et al., 2022; Zhai & Wibowo, 2023).

Despite the comprehensive approach, this study has limitations. The small sample size may not represent the broader population, reducing the generalizability of the findings. Additionally, the reliance on self-reported data introduces the risk of bias, as participants may overestimate or underestimate their experiences and attitudes. Future research should involve larger, more diverse samples to enhance representativeness. Studies could also incorporate objective measures alongside self-reports to mitigate bias and provide a more accurate assessment of AI tools' impact on writing. Further exploration into the long-term effects of AI integration in educational settings and the development of standardized guidelines for ethical AI use in writing would be beneficial.

5. Conclusion

This research aimed to understand EFL students' experiences and strategies when using ChatGPT in their writing. Key findings indicate that ChatGPT is highly valued for overcoming uncertainties, clarifying vocabulary, and offering content suggestions, thereby enhancing the overall quality of essays by allowing students to focus on creative and intellectual aspects. However, the balance between AI tools and human judgment is crucial for maintaining authenticity. While ChatGPT offers substantial benefits, it raises concerns about the authenticity of academic work. Clear guidelines on the ethical use of AI and fostering critical thinking are essential. ChatGPT's limitations, such as providing overly complex suggestions and lacking cultural sensitivity, underscore the need for human oversight. Students recognize the importance of using their judgment and frequently seek feedback from teachers or peers to ensure their work's quality. EFL students also used ChatGPT in various ways, from linguistic refinement to brainstorming, demonstrating its flexibility. These strategies highlight AI's potential to support learning by providing tailored feedback and adjustments. Therefore, educators should develop ethical guidelines for AI use in writing, emphasizing critical thinking and originality. Comprehensive training programs for teachers and students on integrating AI responsibly are essential. AI developers should enhance cultural sensitivity and provide customizable feedback to align with diverse writing styles. Reflecting on the future of AI in education, especially EFL writing, we must embrace AI's potential while prioritizing ethical use and critical thinking. By combining ethical guidelines, comprehensive training, and advanced AI development, we can ensure that students benefit from AI advancements without compromising their personal growth, creativity, and academic integrity. AI in education promises to transform learning experiences by making them more accessible and personalized. Addressing ethical practices, improving AI tools, and fostering human creativity and critical thinking will allow us to harness AI's power to enhance educational outcomes and prepare students for a future where technology and human ingenuity coexist.

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